

**26 April 1986****EXPLOSION AT CHERNOBYL**

The world's worst nuclear disaster occurred when a safety test on a reactor at a power plant in Ukraine (then part of the USSR) went wrong, causing an uncontrolled chain reaction. The resulting explosion and fire released radioactivity that spread across large areas of western Europe. A 10 km (6 mile) exclusion zone was set up around the site, but even so some 60 individuals are reckoned to have died as a direct result of the accident, with estimates of long-term increased mortality ranging into the thousands.

◁ Chernobyl after the explosion

9 November 1989 The Berlin Wall falls in the first step to German reunification

1989

15 April 1986 The US bombs "terrorist-related" targets in Libya, striking at the ports of Tripoli and Benghazi

20 August 1988 The war between Iran and Iraq ends after almost eight years

**8 December 1987
INF TREATY SIGNED**

Negotiated between the US and the USSR, the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces (INF) Treaty was signed by presidents Reagan and Gorbachev and ratified the following June. It banned short- and medium-range land-based missiles, leading to the elimination of over 2,500 weapons and a 10-year programme of on-site verification inspections. In 2019, US President Donald Trump first suspended and then withdrew from the treaty, citing claimed Russian non-compliance.



◁ Pershing II missiles

